

An open-air museum of medieval temples amid surreal boulderscapes

At a Glance

State	Karnataka
District	Vijayanagara District
UNESCO	Group of Monuments at Hampi — WHS since 1986
Best Time	October – February
Airport	Hubli (~143 km) / Ballari (~74 km)
Famous For	Vijayanagara ruins, musical pillars, boulder landscapes, houseboat canals

Overview

Hampi is one of the most extraordinary archaeological landscapes in Asia — the ruins of Vijayanagara, the once-magnificent capital of the Vijayanagara Empire that ruled most of South India between the 14th and 16th centuries. At its peak the city was among the largest in the world, with a population exceeding 500,000 and trade connections to Persia, China, Portugal and Arabia.

Spread across 4,100 hectares, Hampi's 1,600+ surviving structures include grand temples, royal enclosures, elephant stables, market streets, step-wells, aqueducts, and bath complexes. The setting itself is extraordinary — the entire landscape is strewn with ancient granite boulders balanced impossibly atop each other, creating a surreal backdrop that makes Hampi unlike any other heritage site on the planet.

Top Attractions

Virupaksha Temple

The oldest continuously functioning temple in Hampi and its spiritual heart, dedicated to Lord Shiva. Its 49-metre tower (gopuram) dominates the skyline; elephants bless visitors at the entrance and the temple has been in unbroken worship since the 7th century CE.



■ *Virupaksha Temple*

Vittala Temple & Stone Chariot

The architectural pinnacle of Vijayanagara: here stand the famous Musical Pillars — granite columns that produce distinct musical tones when tapped — and the iconic stone chariot (Garuda Ratha) that has become the symbol of Karnataka tourism.



■ *Vittala Temple & Stone Chariot*

Royal Enclosure & Mahanavami Dibba

The ceremonial platform from which Vijayanagara emperors reviewed the grand Mahanavami festival parades. Its three terraces are covered in continuous narrative relief carvings depicting processions, wrestlers, horses, elephants and dancing girls.



■ *Royal Enclosure & Mahanavami Dibba*

Matanga Hill Sunrise

Climb 700 stone steps in darkness to be rewarded at dawn by the most spectacular panoramic view in Hampi — temple spires, amber boulders, banana plantations, and the silver Tungabhadra River stretching to the horizon.



■ *Matanga Hill Sunrise*

Local Cuisine & Flavours

- Bisi Bele Bath — Karnataka's beloved hot lentil-rice-vegetable one-pot dish finished with ghee
- Ragi Mudde with Saaru — finger-millet balls served with thin pepper-rasam style soup
- Set Dosa — soft, spongy triple-dosa with coconut chutney and mixed vegetable sagu
- Obbattu (Holige/Puran Poli) — sweet lentil-stuffed flatbread, a Karnataka festival staple
- Hampi cafés also serve international food — falafel, pasta, Israeli breakfast — for the backpacker trail

How to Get There

- By Air: Hubli Airport (~143 km, ~3 hrs drive) or Ballari Airport (~74 km, ~1.5 hrs).
- By Train: Hospet Junction (~13 km) connects to Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Mumbai and Goa.
- By Road: 350 km from Bengaluru (~6 hrs via NH150A); overnight buses available.

• Local: Rent a bicycle or hire an auto-rickshaw — walking and cycling are ideal for the site.

Insider Travel Tips

• Rent a bicycle — it's the perfect pace for exploring the ruins spread over many kilometres.
• Visit Vittala Temple at opening time (8 AM) — the afternoon heat and crowds are brutal.
• Stay at least 3 nights to properly cover both the Sacred Centre and the Royal Enclosure.
• The Hampi Utsav cultural festival (usually November) brings classical dance to temple stages.
• Best photography: the golden hour when boulders turn amber-red — never skip the sunset.

*We hope this guide inspires your journey to **Hampi — Karnataka**. Travel responsibly, respect local traditions, and leave only footprints.*